

By 1933, Getty interests owned nearly 260,000 Tide Water shares—a block too large to be ignored. I was elected to the company's board, but it was a hollow victory. I was only one among many, and the other directors were still ranged solidly against me and my proposals. I continued to buy Tide Water stock. Proxy fights, lawsuits and countersuits ensued. Injunctions, restraining orders and writs flew in blizzards.

By late 1937, Getty interests owned enough stock to obtain a voice in management. Three years later, we held 1,734,577 shares—a shade over one fourth the voting stock, and many changes I proposed were being implemented. By

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1951, I held enough Tidewater stock to have numerical control. (By then, the "Associated" had been dropped from the company name and "Tide Water" contracted into a single word.) Two years later, with all but one director elected by Getty interests, the campaign was finally over. Today, Tidewater's assets exceed \$800,000,000.

In 1938, I turned momentarily from the oil business and bought the Hotel Pierre in New York City, purchasing it for \$2,350,000, less than one fourth its original (1929-1930) cost. Later, I bought several hundred acres of land in Acapulco, Mexico, where I eventually built the Pierre Marques Hotel on Revolcadero Beach. These, contrary to reports which have me owning a string of hotels, are the only ones I own.

In 1937, as part of the Tide Water campaign, I obtained control of a firm known as the Mission Corporation. Among Mission's holdings was a 57-percent interest in the Skelly Oil Company, a major oil firm with headquarters in Tulsa, Oklahoma. Thus, almost as a windfall, I acquired the controlling interest in a company with a 1937 net income of \$6,400,000—and which, today, has more than \$330,000,000 in assets.

But this is not the whole story. Among Skelly Oil's subsidiaries was the Spartan Aircraft Corporation, a Tulsa concern engaged since 1928 in manufacturing aircraft and training pilots and navigators. I paid my first visit to the Spartan plant on December 7, 1939. Its aircraft-manufacturing